

MODIFICATION OF INDIVIDUAL CHALLENGE IN TEAM-BASED TRAINING IN ELITE AUSTRALIAN RULES FOOTBALL: A CASE STUDY

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INTRODUCTION

An important consideration for coaches is whether their training design is adequately challenging athletes. The Challenge Point Framework [1] proposes that not all conditions are equally beneficial for learning, but that an 'optimal' challenge point may be achieved by modifying the difficulty of a task relative to an individual athlete's ability. In team sport settings, factors such as experience and playing position may mean that a drill is optimally challenging for some athletes, while being over- or under-challenging for others [1, 2]. One method of modifying the challenge of training is through manipulating task constraints (e.g., player numbers and space, and rules) [3]. These constraints can be useful for adapting team behaviour, and may also influence factors such as decision-making, and technical and tactical demands. Manipulating task constraints may therefore offer coaches a practical method of individualising challenge within team-based training, where athletes may perceive the same drill differently. Thus, the aim of the current study was to explore how individual task constraint modifications within a team-based drill influenced athlete behaviour and perceived challenge.

METHODS

Using a mixed-method case study, coaches at an elite men's Australian Rules Football club selected two athletes to receive constraints during a 5-versus-5 Small-Sided Game (SSG) across three sessions: baseline (unmodified), a one-second disposal (time) constraint, and a forward-movement-only (direction) constraint. After each SSG, all athletes completed the Rating of Perceived Challenge (RPC; 0-10) [4]. Notational analysis quantified the constrained athletes' behaviours (e.g., disposal efficiency, disposal duration). Semi-structured interviews with the athletes and coaches explored perceptions of the constraints.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Both constraints altered the athletes' behaviour (e.g., faster disposal speed and higher metres gained) and their perceived challenge (Athlete 1: $RPC_{Baseline}=4$, $RPC_{Time}=8$, $RPC_{Direction}=5$; Athlete 2: $RPC_{Baseline}=6$, $RPC_{Time}=5$, $RPC_{Direction}=5$). Reflexive Content Analysis [5] identified four categories from the interviews

describing how constraints impacted performance: *options*, *time*, *cognitive demands*, and *playing style*. Athlete 1 perceived both constraints as more challenging than baseline, especially the time constraint, as it reduced his time and options, and differed from his preferred playing style. Athlete 2 reported slightly lower challenge under both constraints as they reduced available options which decreased the cognitive demands. Coaches attributed these differences to positional roles and strengths.

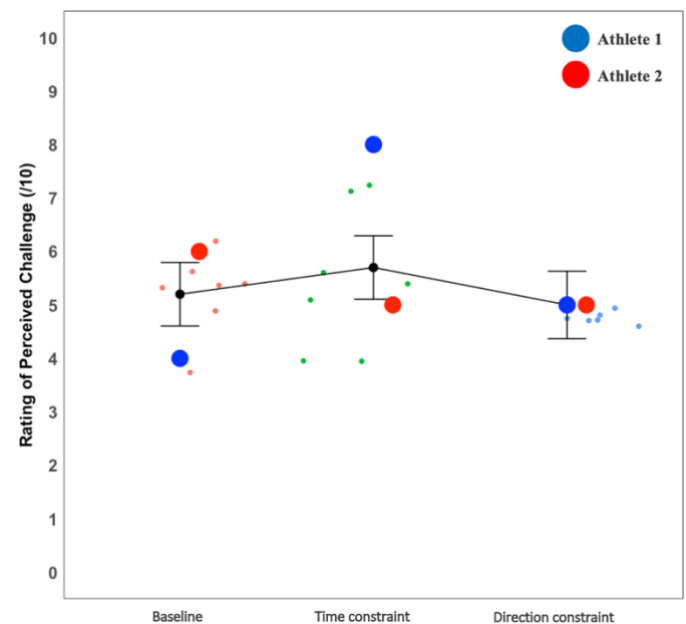


Figure 1 Athlete Rating of Perceived Challenge responses.

CONCLUSIONS

While both athletes adapted their behaviour to meet the constraints, perceived challenge differed based on athlete-specific factors. Coach insight and role-specific knowledge were critical to understanding athlete responses.

REFERENCES

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